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Leading AI at Enterprise Scale: From Influence to Accountability

Enterprises are operationalizing artificial intelligence at scale, moving from experimentation to accountability. Gabriele Ricci of Takeda and Board Director Karenann Terrell discuss how leaders can embed AI into core operations, address unfinished digital foundations, and measure success by outcomes—not through pilots.

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FULL TRANSCRIPT

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Brian Kamenetzky: CIOs have long been expected to be the technical gurus of the enterprise and service to the business, but today they're visionaries, evangelists, and change agents who are the leaders in tech, successfully challenging the status quo and driving transformational change across the business. This is Techfluential, a podcast series hosted by custom content from WSJ and Deloitte. I'm Brian Kamenetzky, senior editor at Custom Content from WSJ. With our host, Lou DiLorenzo, principal at Deloitte Consulting LLP. Lou, it's great to talk with you again.

Lou DiLorenzo: You too, Brian. Great to see you.

Brian Kamenetzky: This is the eighth episode of Techfluential, but many of our listeners, they are new to the show. Can you explain what it means to be techfluential and why that matters?

Lou DiLorenzo: For me, it starts with the idea that there's never been a better time to be a technology executive. Any business strategy is driven by or influenced by or requires the thoughtful application of technology to drive results. And we're seeing an incredible convergence between those that are leading enterprises commercially and those that are the tech executive. They've come together and converged at this unique moment. And so, for me, techfluential is how do these leaders work together? How do they influence outcomes across the organization? And how do they develop a little bit of that mutual language to make sure that they're rising to the occasion?

Brian Kamenetzky: On the last episode of Techfluential, Moderna's Tracy Franklin, and Heidrick & Struggles' Katie Graham Shannon, shared how forward-looking leaders are re-imagining roles, empowering teams, and shaping a more connected and adaptive future workforce. How does that influence who's joining today's episode?

Lou DiLorenzo: We're really at an inflection point with AI, and today we're going to examine this shift from experimentation into enterprise

infrastructure from two critical angles, the driver's seat and the boardroom. I'm thrilled to be joined by Gabriele Ricci, chief data and technology officer at Takeda. And Karenann Terrell, board member, advisor, and former chief digital and technology officer across many industries.

Brian Kamenetzky: Lou, you've covered a lot of ground across these now eight episodes of the show. Where does this conversation fit into that broader arc of the series, and why does it feel like a turning point?

Lou DiLorenzo: To a certain extent, it actually is not specific to technology at the end of the day. It's really about earning that influence through reshaping roles, anticipating what's needed. How do you create high performing teams? How do you drive results? You really can't have influence and not own the accountability and the outcomes of what you've done. And I think that is the arc, is how do you create influence? How do you wield influence thoughtfully? And how do you make sure you're equipped to own the outcomes that come with that? And as I've said before, I think the table is set for technology executives to rise to that occasion and to take a seat at the table. And what do they need to do to sit at it thoughtfully?

Brian Kamenetzky: Okay. Let's get to it then. Here's Deloitte's Lou DiLorenzo with Gab Ricci and Kat Terrell.

Lou DiLorenzo: There's so much happening in the space of technology. And again, as we think about driving enterprise transformations at scale, a lot of great experimentation is happening, but this is really about the pivot point of getting to scale in that breakthrough moment. Gab, I'd love to get your thoughts on what great leadership looks like in the age of AI.

Gabriele Ricci: Great leadership is really about clarity. As AI moves from experimentations into day-to-day operations, I think leaders need to be clearer about few things. Where AI is actually being used, what decisions it supports or makes, and who's accountable for that outcomes. And that clarity is what allow AI to scale. And what's different this time is where AI operates. I think in the past, technology mostly set alongside the business or on the business, supporting people, digitizing processes, providing insight. Now AI operates inside the system, embedded directly into

workflows and in some cases also taking action. And that raises basically the bar, because responsibility can be pushed off to one function. The leaders who get this right really treat AI as part of how the company runs. It's embedded into core processes, it's owned by the business, it's governed responsibly, and it's actually measured on real outcomes. And when that happens, AI stops being an initiative and become part of the operating fabric of the enterprise.

Lou DiLorenzo: Gab, I love that, especially that clarity across those dimensions that you articulated. Kat, you have all kinds of game film from your previous roles and obviously the number of boards that you sit on. And I know you've seen great leaders in action around transformation in this space. I would love to get your thoughts in here on, what does it mean to be a great leader in the age of AI?

Karenann Terrell: I've been around long enough to have seen the transformational change of technology when the internet came in the 2000s. The winners, the people that really embraced early had a couple of characteristics which are showing themselves again to really be successful. The first one is the going together leadership style. No single hero actions were actually going to be the driver of success. I think the other characteristic which is enormously important is understanding risk. And it's the risk in the business domain. It's the risk in the process being right or not right. It's the risk associated with the change management and what's going to happen at scale. And AI is a fundamentally different animal because it's probabilistic. It has stochastic capabilities as opposed to if then we do one thing and discreetly something else happens. I think leadership, which actually has a lens around the risk elements that are included in the opportunity that you're going to have, has never been more important.

Lou DiLorenzo: Gab, I'd love to get a flavor for how you're evaluating those pieces and demonstrating results and progress.

Gabriele Ricci: The clearest signal is that AI is no longer something teams try, something that the business expects to work reliably and every day. And together, we see that shift maybe in three concrete ways. First, AI is embedded directly into core flows. R&D, supply chain, quality, commercial,

it's not really sitting in labs or pilots. And second is value ownership, that really has moved to the business. And leaders now are accountable, not just for experimenting with AI, but for outcomes it enables: cycle time, quality, patient impact. And third, AI is now part of how we found and govern the enterprise, not just the innovation side. And what has to change first is the leadership behavior, as we said before.

Lou DiLorenzo: Yeah, I couldn't agree more with that. My experience is that gen AI and the nature of this conversation, AI more broadly, has been the ultimate mechanism for a more thoughtful conversation between commercial executives and technology executives. Kat, from the board perspective, as AI moves from pilots into the core of the business, what are the foundational questions that boards should be asking to assess not only the underlying technology readiness, but the organization's AI fluency to achieve that scale?

Karenann Terrell: I find that more and more you will hear in a board, "Have we got the right foundation in place?" But it only comes after you get stuck the first or second time. Because when you can't go from a pilot all the way into a full driven rollout in an organization, it's only because of one of two things. Either the digital transformation's not done and you don't have the base to actually scale something like that, or there's something in the AI fluency inside of the organization that has stopped people from understanding, "This is actually going to make me better in my job, or this is going to make the company better." I think when you see those two things being stuck, the questions that have to appear, whether they are in the audit committee or whether it's in the full board is, have we completed the transformation? Is it fully funded? I think whether there is somebody that holds a technology remit at the table of a board or not, and increasingly more in public companies there's at least one and maybe two. Those questions about the foundation are incredibly important. The questions are not significantly different than they were in the discrete technology age, they're just much more urgent.

Lou DiLorenzo: Wonderful. Gab, what are some of the metrics and measures that you and the leadership team are focused on to help understand the rate of progress that you're making?

Gabriele Ricci: Yeah. And connecting to what Kat just said, I think that this connection that I experienced actually with my board, coming back to the previous question, is about how management often talk about AI in terms of activity, in terms of volume, number of use cases, number of pilots, number of models, white boards, but also CEOs are readily focused on value, on risk and resiliency. They don't want to know how much AI we are doing and they want to know what changes because of it. Is it improving outcomes? Is it safe? It is embedded deeply enough that the organization can depend on it? And to close the gap, I think leaders have to translate AI into a board level or CEO language. That means fewer demos and more operational metrics. Where AI sits in critical processes, how decisions are governed, what happens when it fails, and how value is measured over time. And when AI is discussed with the same rigor, as I said before, capital location, risk management, the conversation between management and the board and CEOs becomes much more agile and much more productive.

Lou DiLorenzo: Maybe staying on that for a minute as we think about the digital workforce that many companies are going to continue to experience and mature. How should leaders be thinking about the role of the digital employee? Or, what does it mean for humans to have digital colleagues on their team?

Gabriele Ricci: Yeah, I think the biggest change is that leaders have to start managing AI the way they manage people, just with different controls and skills. And when AI becomes a digital workforce, questions shift from what can this tool do to who's accountable for its actions, its outcomes, and its evolution over time. Every AI capability needs a clear business owner, just like a role in an organizational chart. Someone is responsible for performance, for risk, for continuous improvement. And where leader most underestimates the change is on the human side. This isn't primarily about reskilling everyone into becoming data scientist. It's about changing how work is designed, how humans and AI collaborate, how decisions are made, and how leaders create trust and adoption. And one thing leaders often overlook is the workforce reality we are aiding to very soon. We'll have five generations working side by side with very different expectations about how work gets done. And I think it's our responsibility to smooth over those

differences is to really enable each generation to perform at its best. And that means reimagining how work and collaboration happen, knowing that agentic AI will completely shape roles, especially at the more junior levels. And as leaders, we have the responsibility to bring an AI native generation into the enterprise, as this generation is the most impacted by agentic AI, and give them a real run through the company.

Lou DiLorenzo: Well, I think your point on five generations is astonishing, actually. I hadn't appreciated that, the way you just delivered it, and it has so many implications. In practical terms, what does it mean for agents to be collaborators and teammates? What does that really look like?

Gabriele Ricci: Everyone is now a coworker, and this fundamentally starts with imagining these end-to-end processes at enterprise levels where we can apply automation through agents, but when we have humans in the loop for a risk, for compliance, for ethical reasons. And both these should work together.

Karenann Terrell: I think the early elements of automation got people to see that is something that can be done to reduce the toil or to improve things for me, and never thought of it as something that is a continual learning entity that will get better and better the more we use it, the more people use it, et cetera. And when a data scientist for everybody sits on your shoulder, that level of capability sits there as a coworker. That collegiality is, "Okay, well, now I'm just smarter. Now I'm more available."

Lou DiLorenzo: Kat, from a risk and oversight in all the core functions of a board, this is a significant transformation. What are some of the things that you would be looking at to make sure that this is an accelerator, so that it's additive to the enterprise and not creating unintended consequences?

Karenann Terrell: I think you have to really separate these two things. Because AI as a driven opportunity around P&L has a very distinct conversation that takes place with the senior executive team and the board. The second part of it is the productivity improvements, the efficiencies, and what KPIs we have looked at previously are hard dollar opportunities associated with SG&A. How do we reduce the cost of what we're doing

here? Those types of operational measures that we use are incredibly, incredibly valuable now in the age of AI. It is super, super important that we have a set of conversations about these two things differently. Because one is about driving opportunities and the other is an application of AI more vertically to a set of problems, which we've been trying to solve with technology for years. Those types of things now that are being improved, there are much more solid value indicators. We just have to get our CFOs and our CHROs to recognize fully implemented how impactful those things may be.

Lou DiLorenzo: Well, you both have talked about how quickly this space is evolving, and obviously different perspectives and implications. Are there things that you're doing on your own to stay current and relevant? What do you think, Gab?

Gabriele Ricci: Yeah, I think we need to stay amble. We need to constantly check our peers, what they're doing, but also look outside our industry, because other industries already accelerated the transformation. And I think for us, now more than ever, are asked to look far ahead two, three, four years far from now, knowing that the environment is very volatile and is changing very rapidly. But the only way to stay competitive is actually adapting and changing and evolving faster than ever. And I think learning from our peers is a good way to stay relevant.

Karenann Terrell: Can I pick up on one of those topics?

Lou DiLorenzo: Please, yeah.

Karenann Terrell: Because the ecosystem associated with AI where you really see players that are coming not from necessarily technology routes, but from math routes, and they are moving in universities, tons and tons of them sitting at venture or vulture capital stages right now that are moving through. These are AI natives. And a lot of these AI natives are not actually employees of our companies, they're part of a very, very complex ecosystem. I think the tit-for-tat in this new evolving ecosystem is one that enterprises are going to have to get a lot more comfortable with playing together. They may not be scaled yet, they may not be fully funded, but they

certainly come from a completely different paradigm of AI native and math oriented as they drive through models. The new players have got some very new ideas.

Gabriele Ricci: Kat, to build on what you said, because you talk about the ecosystem, I love that part. Specifically, I think we, for example in pharma, I have the responsibility to work with my peers to reshape the industry. It's a matter of survival. If you don't collaborate together to reimagine pharma end to end, how we discover, how we manufacture and deliver therapies to our patients, ultimately the patients will suffer. It's about our mission and our core. I think this synergistic approach is crucial for the future of the entire industry. I completely agree with you.

Lou DiLorenzo: As we think about the winners in this journey, those that are able to build competitive advantage and serve their customers differently, what's the one leadership capability you think is required to be that winner over a, call it two to three year cycle? Gab?

Gabriele Ricci: Yeah, I was buying because we are a 244-year-old company, and now looking to how the market and the world is changing the next three, four years is like having the crystal ball. But if I need to think about a single biggest differentiator, probably is the ability to move from enthusiasm to accountability. I think leaders who successfully scale AI will be very clear about who owns outcomes. So not pilots, not platforms, but really results. They redesign roles, incentives, and operating models so AI can be really embedded into how work actually gets done and not layered on top. And leaders also will still be talking about transformation as a future state. I think in two or three years the difference will be quite obvious. In one group, AI will be invisible because it's an integral part of the business. In the other one, still be very visible and still being explained to the rest of the organization.

Lou DiLorenzo: I love that. Kat, would love to get your thoughts.

Karenann Terrell: Yeah, I think every culture of a company is different, and AI is going to actually embrace the culture of the company, not change it. I think the winners are ones that, in two to three years, they are the same

companies in terms of their culture, the way they make decisions, the type of talent that they hire, et cetera. The difference will be how they have harnessed the talent internally horizontally as opposed to in any level of silo. Because AI has massively collapsed silos, silos of data, silos of customer information, silos of capabilities. And I mean silos inside the company and outside the companies. I think this level of horizontal thinking is going to be a differentiator of people who have taken the priorities in the company for the use of AI and actually made it happen operationally. It got embedded into the execution system that's being managed and the production system that's being used. Top companies are going to have embraced their cultures in order to drive AI directly into the things that matter in their industry and company.

Lou DiLorenzo: At the end of every episode, I ask people to tell us what techfluential means to them. Kat, with your experience and boardroom perspective, I'd love to start with you.

Karenann Terrell: Techfluential is, are you able to actually grasp technology, and in whatever environment you're in, be influential with the people that you work with and around? For me, that's board members, that's CIOs that I am hoping to lift in their role, current and future. It's taking technology in everything that you know about it and being influential in your environment.

Lou DiLorenzo: Fabulous. Gab, we'll turn it over to you.

Gabriele Ricci: I think (inaudible), people don't talk about the technology anymore, they talk about what changed because of it. If the conversation is still about the tool, the models, the platform, probably haven't done my job well. And when it's about faster decisions, better outcomes, work that simply feels different, I think that's influence. It isn't about being the loudest voice in the room. It's about creating the conditions where others lead differently because technology changed what was possible. If I should use a phrase, it's about influence is silence about the tech and being loud about the outcomes.

Lou DiLorenzo: Powerful themes. We talk a lot about how leadership matters, and I think you both have shared certainly firsthand stories. And Gab, loved hearing the work you're driving at Takeda and the philosophy. And I think there's a lot that others can learn. And Kat, certainly your perspective from the board in terms of how to encourage that and the types of questions. Wonderful perspectives. Thank you both for being here.

Gabriele Ricci: Thanks a lot. Thanks, Kat, for your insight as well.

Karenann Terrell: Yeah, absolute. Fun conversation.

Gabriele Ricci: Thanks, Lou.

Brian Kamenetzky: Thanks, Lou. There was a lot to take away from that conversation, but what in particular stuck out to you?

Lou DiLorenzo: There was a powerful messages on what great leadership looks like in the age of AI. This whole idea of focus and accountability for AI's outcomes and really impacting the business, it really has to disappear into work into the operations. Just that orientation of bringing it so close to the work and to make it part of what happens in the day-to-day fabric, I think that's going to separate winners and losers in this space.

Brian Kamenetzky: Thanks, Lou. I'm really looking forward to the next episode, where we'll continue exploring the role of technology leadership and what it means to be techfluential. Thanks everyone for listening.

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